The turning point, according to the Resolution, came in early 1965 when Mao took his thesis on class struggle further by arguing that the main target must be ‘those Party persons in power taking the capitalist road’. [7] This is taken as the prelude to the launch of the Great Proletarian Cultural Revolution, which is condemned as being responsible for ‘the most severe setback and the heaviest losses suffered by the Party, the state and the people since the founding of the PRC. It was initiated and led by Comrade Mao Zedong’. [8]

In criticizing Mao for the personality cult that grew around him, the Resolution stated:

> During this period, his theoretical and tactical mistakes concerning class struggle in a socialist society became increasingly serious, his personal arbitrariness gradually undermined democratic centralism in Party life and the personality cult grew graver and graver. The Central Committee of the Party failed to rectify these mistakes in good time. Careerists like Lin Biao (Defence Minister), Jiang Qing (Mao’s wife) and Kang Sheng (security chief), harbouring ulterior motives, made use of these errors and inflated them. This led to the inauguration of the Cultural Revolution. [9]

Its final assessment of Mao is damning:

> History has shown that the cultural revolution initiated by a leader labouring under a misapprehension and capitalized upon by counter-revolutionary cliques led to domestic turmoil and brought catastrophe to the Party, the state and the people. [10]

The Resolution goes on to narrate the dramatic events which unfolded following the death of Zhou Enlai in January 1976, and of Mao himself in September the same year. The ultra-Left group of leaders on whom he had relied to continue his project of the Cultural Revolution – Jiang Qing, Wang Hongwen, Zhang Chunqiao and Yao Wenyaun, the so-called ‘Gang of Four’ – were arrested and detained in October, paving the way for the return of Deng Xiaoping. This brought to an end the ten-year period of political turmoil and economic setbacks. However, it was only in 1978 at the Third Plenum of the Eleventh Central Committee that Deng was able to establish his undisputed leadership and clear the decks for the subsequent economic Reform and Opening-Up Policy which, in a period of just four decades, has transformed China into an economic powerhouse second only to the US, with international influence to match. That trajectory will be the subject of